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Antecedents to boundary-spanner perceived organizational support

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Abstract *Owing to their growing numbers and importance, both managers and researchers are increasingly concerned with the work experiences of boundary-spanning employees. Employee perceptions of organizational support (POS) may be particularly relevant to this crucial employee group. Thus reports a study of the relations between two individual-level and two organizational-level antecedents to boundary-spanner POS. The results indicate that employee gender, amount of formal organizational recognition received, and the quality of task-related training are associated with POS. However, type of employee pay plan is not. Concludes with a discussion of these findings and their implications for effectively managing boundary-spanning employee POS.*

Understanding and appreciating the role of organizational variables are important to those who also wish to understand employee job outcomes. Owing to their very nature, organizational variables represent broad and pervasive characteristics of the work environment that impact all members of the organization, including its boundary-spanning employees such as salespeople, service and repair technicians, etc. Babin and Boles (1998) observe that front-line boundary-spanners represent a rapidly expanding proportion of a firm's total number of employees and that they occupy a critical role towards influencing the customer's experience with the firm.

Accordingly, properly managing the work experiences of these critical employees is an important organizational and managerial task. However, because boundary-spanning employees operate between the firm and its environment, they often spend a large portion of their time outside the firm and so the influence of organizational variables is likely to be filtered and dampened. While this may help to explain the modest relationship between organizational variables and the job performance of boundary-spanning salespeople (Churchill *et al.*, 1985), it does not diminish the need to understand the relations between the



two. If anything, this situation highlights the importance of identifying not only those variables that are associated with boundary-spanner work experiences but also those that the firm is able to impact.

Research on boundary-spanning employees, most commonly salespeople, has examined the role of organizational variables such as values (Flaherty *et al.*, 1999), competitive psychological climate (Brown *et al.*, 1998), level of training and compensation (Babakus *et al.*, 1996), general management practices (Singh *et al.*, 1996), and socialization and climate (Kelley, 1992). As a result, our understanding of the relations between organizational variables and the work experiences of this crucial group of boundary-spanning employees continues to improve. The purpose of this research is to contribute to this growing body of knowledge by examining some of the characteristics associated with an important organizational variable of potentially great importance to boundary-spanners – perceived organizational support (POS). First, the literature on employee POS will be reviewed and its relevance to boundary-spanning employees discussed. Next, a group of characteristics that may be associated with boundary-spanner POS are presented and the hypotheses describing the relations are detailed. In the third section, the sample and methodology used to test the hypotheses are described. The results of the study and their managerial implications are presented in the final section.

Perceived organizational support

Defined as the employee's "global beliefs concerning the extent to which the organization values their contributions and cares about their wellbeing," (Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986, p. 501), POS represents the employee's perceptions of the organization's commitment to him or her. The concept of POS is based on a social exchange interpretation of organizational commitment, whereby employees extend their effort and loyalties to the organization in return for the material commodities and social rewards it can bestow (Blau, 1964). Eisenberger *et al.* (1986, p. 501) suggest that POS is "influenced by various aspects of an employee's treatment by the organization," including "the frequency, extremity, and judged sincerity of statements of praise and approval . . . pay, rank, job enrichment, and influence over organizational policies." They also propose that two "attributional heuristics" (Eisenberger *et al.*, 1986) might influence employee POS: unique favors or actions granted by the firm to individual employees and altruistic organizational actions, whereby the employee does not perceive the need to reciprocate. Lastly, due to employee tendencies to personify the organization, Eisenberger *et al.* (1986) propose that actions by the employee's manager may also be important in developing employee perceptions of organizational support.

POS is of interest to firms and managers because of its close association with greater levels of employee commitment in the form of increased effort, attendance, identification with the firm's goals, etc. and also because employee POS may be relatively easy for managers to develop. Subsequent research verified the distinct nature of POS (Shore and Tetrick, 1991; Wayne *et al.*, 1997) and described its relations with a variety of desirable job outcomes in non-boundary-spanning employees including performance (Orpen, 1994;

Eisenberger *et al.*, 1990), intention to quit (Wayne *et al.*, 1997), organizational commitment (Settoon *et al.*, 1996), use of routine and creative discretion (Kelley *et al.*, 1996) and organizational citizenship behaviors (Shore and Wayne, 1993; Moorman *et al.*, 1998). In addition, POS is also associated with the level of non-boundary-spanning employee effort (Orpen, 1994), commitment to and communication about workplace safety (Hoffman and Morgeson, 1999), and the development of a learning organization (Barker and Camarata, 1998).

On reviewing this body of research, two observations can be made. First, few, if any, of these studies examined POS using samples of boundary-spanning employees. Owing to the unique nature of the boundary-spanning employee's tasks, their job-related experiences are often quite different from those of internally situated employees and so too may be their perceptions of organizational support as well as its relations with important job outcomes. For example, due to their boundary-spanning role, salespeople often experience high levels of role ambiguity and conflict, which themselves are strongly associated with decreased satisfaction and performance and increased turnover of staff (Brown and Peterson, 1993). However, boundary-spanners who perceive that the employing firm cares about their wellbeing and is committed to them may experience lower levels of ambiguity and conflict as well as improvements in other job outcomes. Accordingly, understanding the role of boundary-spanner POS may offer researchers and managers an additional means of influencing desirable boundary-spanner job outcomes and of reducing the expense and problems associated with boundary-spanner turnover (Babakus *et al.*, 1996).

The second observation concerning the body of POS research is that researchers have expended most of their efforts towards identifying the outcomes of employee POS. While understanding the outcomes of POS is very important, in order to capitalize on these findings researchers and managers must also understand the factors that influence employee perceptions that the organization supports and values them. Accordingly, researchers should be just as concerned with identifying the antecedents to employee POS as they have been with identifying the job outcomes to which it is related. Churchill *et al.* (1985) conclude that those organizational variables directly subject to specific organizational actions offer managers the best means of influencing employee job outcomes, and POS appears to be particularly subject to firm-administered actions. Eisenberger *et al.* (1986, p. 501) propose that employees rely heavily on the frequency and extremity of formal recognition from the organization, such as pay, rank, job enrichment, and influence over organizational policies, when developing their perceptions of organizational support. Accordingly, the relatively few antecedents to POS that have been examined include altruistic organizational actions such as perceived procedural fairness (Moorman *et al.*, 1998), organizational dependability (Hutchison, 1997) and unique actions associated with individual employees including training and promotions (Wayne *et al.*, 1997).

In this research, both types of antecedents to salesperson POS will be considered. The unique, individual antecedents examined include one

demographic characteristic, i.e. the salesperson's gender, and one job-related characteristic, i.e. the amount of formal organizational recognition received. The two organizational antecedents considered are the type of pay plan the firm uses with its boundary-spanning employees and the employee's perceptions of the quality of the firm's training program. As a result, managers will better understand the relations between both individual and organizational variables and boundary-spanner perceptions of organizational support.

Hypotheses

Gender

As increasing numbers of women enter the workplace and in particular into boundary-spanner positions, the role of employee gender continues to garner the attention of both researchers and managers. Unfortunately, the question of gender differences remains unsettled, as many studies report no significant differences between the sexes, while other research suggests that male and female employees experience their boundary-spanning positions and interactions quite differently (Babin and Boles, 1998; Dubinsky *et al.*, 1993; Schul and Wren, 1992). For example, Comer *et al.* (1998) contend that the job experiences of female salespeople differ from those of male salespeople in that females must cope with negative stereotyping, the devaluation of their performance, communication style incompatibility, and tokenism. In addition, previous research suggests that females depend more on relations with their supervisors (Bergmann, 1986) and desire more continuous reinforcement from their managers (Robertson and Hackett, 1977) than do males. While no research was located that tested for gender differences in employee POS, it may be that gender is an important individual-level antecedent to boundary-spanner POS, as each of these conditions may contribute to perceptions by female employees that they receive less support from the organization. In addition, women may experience less POS, because in many instances their workplace is predominantly male, resulting in female boundary-spanners possibly perceiving that firms value male employees more greatly. Consequently, the first hypothesis states that:

- H1.* Female boundary-spanners experience lower levels of POS than do male boundary-spanners.

Formal organizational recognition

Eisenberger *et al.* (1986) specifically note that the manner in which the firm treats its employees (through managerial actions) should strongly influence the employee's perceptions of organizational support. Formal organizational recognition for quality work is one way for the company to send a message to its employees concerning their perceived value. Employees may believe that rewards granted them reflect the likelihood that the firm will support them in the future (Wayne *et al.*, 1997). In this manner, formal organizational recognition is an individual-level antecedent, as each employee is evaluated and rewarded based on his or her individual contributions. Shore and Shore (1995) propose that pay increases and promotions are common forms of formal organizational recognition.

Wayne *et al.* (1997) found a positive relationship between the number of promotions received and employee POS, while Miceli and Mulvey (2000) report that employee satisfaction with pay is positively associated with POS. Babakus *et al.* (1996) conclude that salesperson perceptions of the fairness of the firm's compensation plan, probably the most formal and powerful example of formal organizational recognition, are positively associated with POS. These findings lead to the second hypothesis:

- H2. The amount of formal organizational recognition received is positively related to boundary-spanner POS.

Type of pay plan

Distinct from the amount and types of formal organizational recognition that a firm may provide its employees are the characteristics of the employee's pay plan. Historically, most firms have compensated their employees via regular monetary payments, e.g. a fixed salary paid out over a particular time period. However, it is now common for many employees to be compensated, at least partially, using a variable pay plan, whereby some component of the employee's pay is based on performance in successfully meeting specific objectives. For example, since many boundary-spanners interact with customers as a central part of their jobs, some firms partially base the employee's compensation in the form of bonuses or other rewards based on measures of customer satisfaction or retention. In particular, salespeople have traditionally earned much if not all of their monetary compensation based on their selling performance.

Over time, the amount of performance-based compensation earned can be highly volatile and this condition could be associated with decreased perceptions of firm support. Because employee behaviors and attitudes partially reflect the employee's perceptions of firm support, and because financial compensation is one of the most overt manifestations of the degree to which the firm values an employee, it is reasonable to expect that the manner in which boundary-spanners are compensated is associated with their level of POS. Boundary-spanners can be compensated in a variety of ways but the most popular means are to use:

- (1) a fixed salary with no variable component;
- (2) a plan solely based on variable performance measures; or
- (3) some combination of fixed and variable components.

While the straight salary plan offers greater certainty to the employee, the entirely variable plan offers the greatest potential income but at the greatest levels of risk and volatility. The combination of fixed and variable components offers a middle ground between these plans that, optimally, offers the best of both.

Employees who receive at least a portion of their compensation via a fixed salary may perceive that the firm supports and values them more strongly because they are assured of receiving at least some compensation each pay period. Support for a general association between compensation and POS is provided by Babakus *et al.* (1996), who found that salesperson perceptions of

the fairness of their compensation plan are positively associated with POS. In addition, Lynch *et al.* (1999) report that POS moderates the relationship between employee wariness of being exploited by the firm and his or her level of job performance. Because employees may perceive that highly variable pay plans, such as commission-only compensation, indicate a lower degree of support and a greater risk of exploitation, employees who work under such a volatile pay environment may also perceive lower levels of organizational support. Accordingly, the following hypothesis will be tested:

- H3. Boundary-spanners compensated solely using performance-based pay plans experience lower levels of POS than do boundary-spanners compensated using (a) a combination or (b) a fixed salary pay plan.

Training quality

Another of the overt means firms may use to indicate their support for and valuation of employees is in the quality of the training it provides them. Employees who are highly valued are likely to receive greater amounts of high-quality training while those who are not so highly valued are less likely to receive training and other development activities. In addition, many firms are increasingly using intangible investments in people, such as training, to influence employee performance, satisfaction and commitment. Shore and Shore (1995) identify training as a type of discretionary developmental experience that firms may provide and which reflects greater levels of investment in its employees. Wayne *et al.* (1997) found a positive association between firm-provided discretionary experiences, such as training, and employee POS. Babakus *et al.* (1996) report that salesperson perceptions of the firm's support for training are also associated with POS. A related question is whether boundary-spanning employees perceive that the quality of the training they receive on their primary tasks is associated with their perceptions of organizational support. If boundary-spanners perceive that they are receiving adequate, high quality task-related training, are they more likely to perceive that the firm values and supports them? The final hypothesis addresses this question by suggesting that:

- H4. Boundary-spanner perceptions of the quality of the firm's task-related training is positively related to boundary-spanner POS.

Research method

Measures

Boundary-spanner perceived organizational support was measured using three items (mean = 4.31, reliability = 0.91, variance extracted = 0.71) adapted from Eisenberger *et al.* (1986), and perceptions of firm training were measured using three items (mean = 4.90, reliability = 0.89, variance extracted = 0.73) adapted from Roberts *et al.* (1994). All used seven-point Likert scales ranging from 1 (strongly disagree) to 7 (strongly agree). Formal organizational recognition was measured by adding together the number of promotions and pay raises each boundary-spanner had received, while gender and type of pay

plan were measured by asking each respondent to mark a category that best described his or her circumstances. The Appendix contains all of the items used in this study.

Sample

Data to examine the hypotheses were collected from a sample of professional boundary-spanning salespeople. One of the researchers attended the annual meeting of the Sales and Marketing Executives International and discussed the proposed research project with mid- and upper-level managers in attendance. In return for a summary of the findings, five sales managers from different firms (four business-to-business service firms and an insurance firm primarily selling to businesses) agreed to distribute questionnaire forms and a stamped return envelope directly to their boundary-spanning salespeople. Throughout the data gathering process the respondents were explicitly notified that their participation was voluntary and that their answers would remain anonymous. Of the 400 questionnaires distributed, 235 were returned directly to the researchers (59 percent response rate). The average respondent was a 41-year-old male with a college degree and ten years of selling experience, who is compensated using a salary-plus-commission pay plan. Table I describes the final sample.

Analysis and results

Before testing the hypotheses, the groups of salespeople from each of the five firms were compared in terms of mean age, years of selling experience, and years with the current firm as well as gender, type of pay plan, and educational level. As no significant differences were found between any of the groups, the entire set of respondents was pooled for analyzing the hypotheses. In addition, because of the unequal group sizes between male and female respondents as well as the three pay plan groups, the variance in POS for each group was compared and was also found to be essentially equal, thus allowing valid comparisons among these unequally sized groups. Next,

Variable	Median	Mean	Number	Percentage
Age	41	41.12		
Years of experience	10	11.51		
Years with current firm	2	4.85		
No. of formal organizational recognitions received from current firm	2	1.89		
Variable				
Gender:			183	77.9
Male				
Female			52	22.1
Type of pay plan:				
Performance only			79	33.6
Salary only			11	4.7
Combination plan			145	61.7

Table I.
Sample descriptive
statistics

confirmatory factor analysis conducted via the SAS algorithm indicated that the completely standardized loadings relating to each of the seven items measuring POS and Training exceeds 0.77 (see Table II), thereby indicating acceptable convergent validity. Based on this analysis, each of the hypotheses was then examined:

- Do female boundary-spanners experience lower levels of POS than male boundary-spanners? Using the Least Squares Means method via SAS, the average level of POS for female boundary-spanners (mean = 3.58) was compared with the average level of POS for male boundary-spanners (mean = 4.29). The results indicate that female boundary-spanners do experience significantly lower POS than males ($p = 0.0034$). Therefore, $H1$ cannot be rejected.
- Is there a positive association between the amount of formal organizational recognition received and boundary-spanner POS? $H2$ was tested using multiple regression, whereby formal organizational recognition and employee perceptions of training quality were jointly regressed on employee POS. The results of this test indicate that formal organizational recognition is positively associated with boundary-spanner POS ($\beta = 0.07$, $p = 0.0003$), so $H2$ cannot be rejected.
- Do boundary-spanners, compensated solely using performance-based pay plans, experience lower levels of POS than boundary-spanners compensated using (a) a combination or (b) a fixed salary pay plan? $H3$ was also examined using the Least Squares Means method while fixing the comparison-wide error rate at $\alpha = 0.05$. In these tests, the mean level of respondent POS for each pay type group, i.e. performance-only (mean = 4.01), combination (mean = 4.29), fixed salary (mean = 3.50), were compared with the others and the results indicate no significant differences in boundary-spanner POS between any of the groups (p -values ranging from 0.09 to 0.29). Therefore, $H3$ is rejected.
- Are boundary-spanner perceptions of the quality of the firm's task-related training positively related to boundary-spanner POS? $H4$ was tested using the same regression equation utilized for testing $H2$. In this equation, boundary-spanner perceptions of the quality of the firm's task-related, i.e. sales, training are associated with increased POS ($\beta = 0.57$, $p = 0.0001$). Accordingly, $H4$ cannot be rejected.

Item	Loading	Item	Loading
POS1	0.77	Train1	0.80
POS2	0.87	Train2	0.94
POS3	0.88	Train3	0.80
POS4	0.84		

Table II.
Completely
standardized item
loadings

Discussion and implications

Owing to its positive relations with several desirable job outcomes, POS appears to be an important aspect of the employee's work experience. The purpose of this research has been to examine the relations between two potential individual and two potential organizational-level antecedents to boundary-spanner POS. As a result, managers and researchers have been provided with a better description of some of the antecedent factors associated with this important aspect of the work environment.

Individual antecedents to boundary-spanner POS

The two individual-level characteristics hypothesized as related to POS were gender and amount of formal organizational recognition received, and both are associated with boundary-spanner perceptions of organizational support. As hypothesized, female boundary-spanners report lower perceptions of organizational support than males. Unfortunately, this research did not address whether female employees actually receive less support or they simply perceive that they do; regardless, female boundary-spanners clearly feel that they receive less support and are not as highly valued. Accordingly, managers may wish to expend greater efforts to support their female boundary-spanners in dealing with the vagaries and volatile nature of their tasks. For a variety of reasons, the work experiences of female boundary-spanners appear to be qualitatively different from those of males, so it may be advisable for managers to attend to the unique needs of their female employees by providing greater amounts and/or clarity of support. For example, managers may consider giving more personal attention to their female employees by inquiring about their work experiences and carefully listening to and considering their comments.

Employees are acutely aware that the amount of formal, organizationally-bestowed recognition they receive, such as promotions and pay raises, is directly related to their individual performance in meeting their assigned objectives. Many boundary-spanners interact with customers as a central part of their jobs and those that regularly meet and/or exceed their assigned objectives are likely to garner greater amounts of formal organizational recognition. These employees are likely to conclude that, because the firm so recognizes them, it also highly values them. Accordingly, *H2* suggests that there exists a positive relationship between the amount of formal organizational recognition a boundary-spanner has earned and his or her level of POS. As this relationship was found to exist, managers should keep in mind that success may indeed breed greater success and, as employees who perform well are rewarded, they may develop perceptions that the firm supports them and in a virtuous circle this perception may enhance the employee's future efforts. Conversely, lower performing boundary-spanners are less likely to be recognized and thus are likely to perceive less firm support. In a destructive circle, this condition may actually dampen their future efforts, thus leading to lower performance, and so on. Managers may wish to search for alternative, informal means of supporting lower

performing employees as one means to help them break out of this cycle, while at the same time ensuring that higher performing employees continue to receive the firm's formal recognition. For example, additional attention, encouragement, training, etc. with lower performing employees may help them realize that the firm values and supports them and may assist them to improve their performance.

Organizational antecedents to boundary-spanner POS

The two organizational characteristics hypothesized as antecedent to boundary-spanner POS were type of pay plan and training, but only training is associated with differing perceptions of organizational support. Employee perceptions of organizational support did not differ with the pay plan used. Perhaps because many boundary-spanners are accustomed to receiving at least part of their compensation based on performance measures (see Table I) and their inherent uncertainty, boundary-spanners may simply not equate their use with a lack of organizational support. Therefore, managers need not fear negatively affecting their boundary-spanning employees' POS by using performance-oriented pay plans; nor, however, can they positively influence it by using pay plans containing a fixed component. In sum, it appears that managers may feel confident choosing the type of pay plan based on other criteria such as attempts to shape and improve employee behaviors.

However, boundary-spanner perceptions of the quality of the firm's task-related training program are positively associated with POS. Boundary-spanning employees depend on training provided by the firm to continuously develop their skills, product and customer knowledge, etc. and likely feel that firms which value and support them will demonstrate this by providing high quality training that contributes to their career development and success. Managers may therefore wish to ensure that boundary-spanners receive appropriate amounts of high quality task-related training, not only to impact their job performance but also to send the signal that the firm values them enough to expend time and money to further develop their skills and knowledge. In addition, managers may wish to determine the extent to which boundary-spanning employees perceive that their training is of sufficient quality, perhaps by ensuring an adequate flow of feedback and suggestions.

Limitations of the study

While three of the four hypotheses of this study were supported and both individual and organizational variables were found to be associated with boundary-spanner POS, the limitations of the study must also be considered. First, the study used cross-sectional data, all of which were gathered from a single source, namely the employee. Consequently, it has been possible only to establish the presence or absence of an association between the variables and further study is needed to identify any causal relations. In addition, the use of a single source for the data may give rise to common method explanations for the

relations discussed and future research may wish to use multiple data sources to avoid these potential problems. While employees from a variety of firms comprised the sample used, these firms are not likely to represent the entire universe of boundary-spanner experiences and the results from a different sample may have led to dissimilar conclusions. Accordingly, future researchers ought to consider utilizing a broader group of firms to enhance the generalizability of their findings or, conversely, narrowing the types of firms used in order to focus on a particular boundary-spanner type. Lastly, it may be advisable to operationalize organizational recognition as more than simply formal organizational actions. As firms continue to flatten their organizational structures, promotions may be less frequent and recognition through job enlargement may be more common. Accordingly, future researchers may wish to include informal recognition such as praise, encouragement, and other non-financial means to better measure the amount and types of both formal and informal support.

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Appendix. Items used to measure constructs

Perceived organizational support

This firm would not ignore complaints from me.

My firm considers my best interests when making decisions.

This firm really cares about my well-being.

My firm cares about my opinions.

Training

My firm provides adequate training for new employees.

My firm provides adequate ongoing training for its employees.

The training I have received has helped me to be successful.

Formal organizational recognition

How many promotions have you received from your current firm?

How many pay raises have you received from your current firm?

Gender

You are: _____ Male _____ Female

Pay Plan

What type of pay plan are you currently under?

_____ Performance only _____ Salary only _____ Combination